

A N A N A L Y T I C S D E E P D I V E

IPL CRUNCH '26

17 seasons. 1,090 matches. 260,920 balls.

5 questions. 1 unexpected truth.

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Submission · Wooble × Unstop · May 2026

Five questions every IPL fan argues about — answered with data

Q1

Does winning the toss actually win you the match?

Q2

Which phase decides the game — Powerplay, Middle, or Death?

Q3

Who are the true top performers across 17 seasons?

Q4

Has the Impact Player rule (2023+) broken the "180 = winning total" rule?

Q5

How much do powerplay wickets really hurt? (Spoiler: more than you think.)

THE METHOD

What we worked with, and how

17

IPL seasons

2007 → 2024

1,090

Matches analyzed

Cleaned + deduped

260,920

Balls of data

Ball-by-ball

9

Visualizations

Built with Python

TOOLS

Python • Pandas • NumPy • Matplotlib • Seaborn • Jupyter / Google Colab

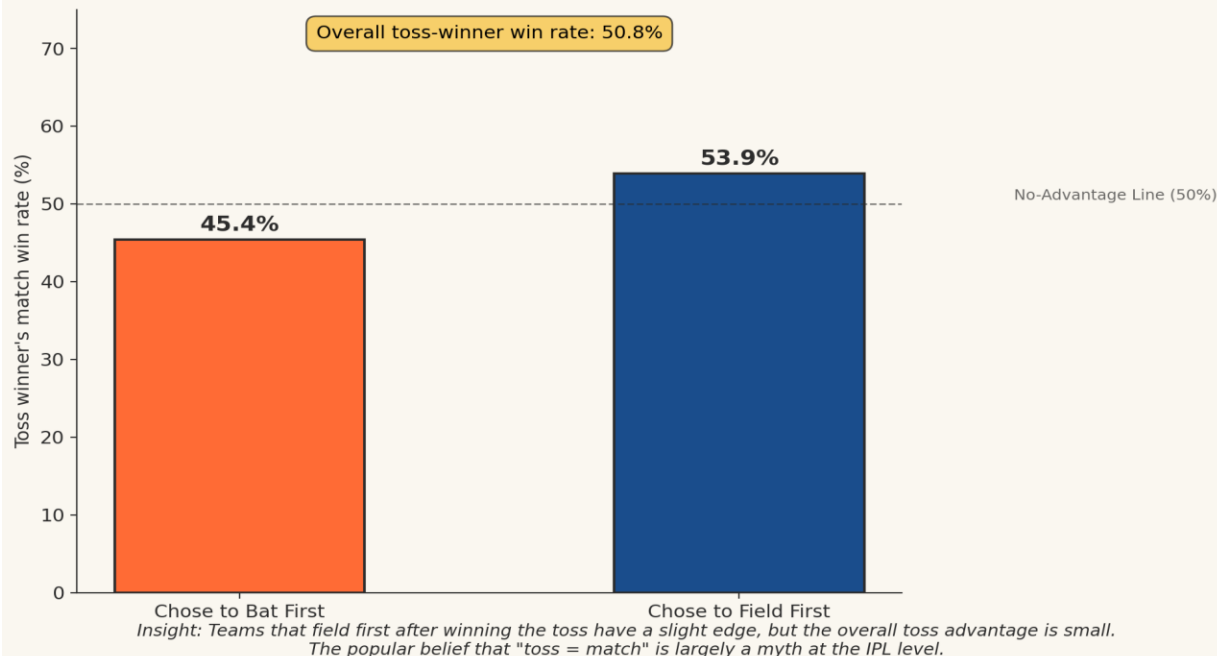
DATA SOURCE

Cricsheet-derived IPL ball-by-ball dataset (matches.csv + deliveries.csv)

Q1

The Toss Myth

THE TOSS MYTH: Winning the toss barely moves the needle



A coin flip is a coin flip.

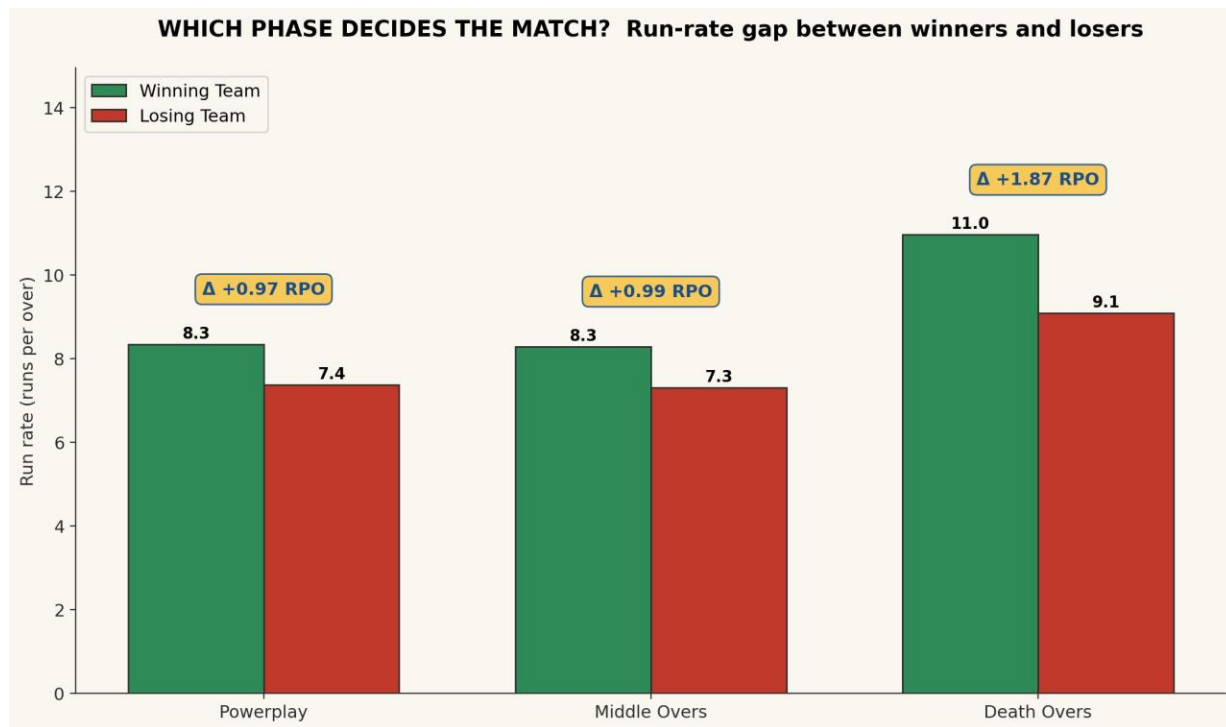
Toss winners win only 50.8% of matches across 17 seasons — barely better than chance.

The real edge hides in the DECISION: field-first wins 54%, bat-first wins just 45%.

The toss is not the match. The choice you make after winning it is.

Q2

Which phase decides the match?



Death overs do the heavy lifting.

Winners outscore losers by 1.87 RPO in death overs — almost double the gap of any other phase.

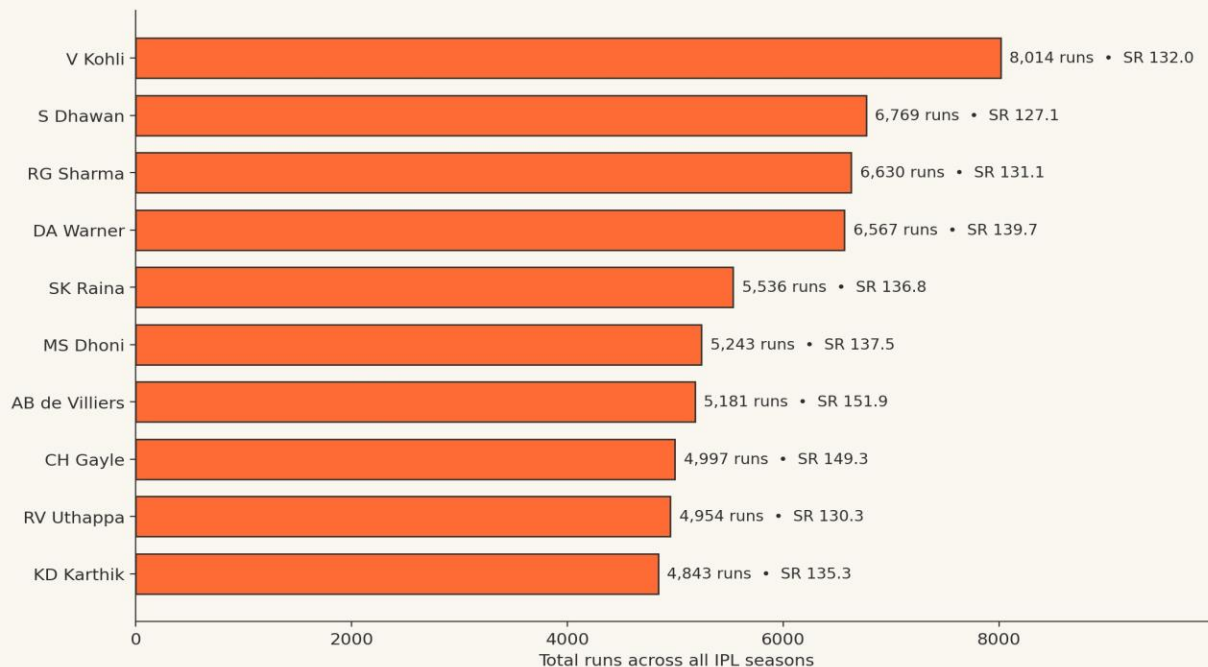
Powerplay and middle-overs deltas are nearly identical (~1.0 RPO).

But notice: every phase favours the winner. There is no "carry phase" in IPL.

Q3

The kings of run-making

TOP 10 IPL RUN-SCORERS (with strike rate)



Kohli stands alone.

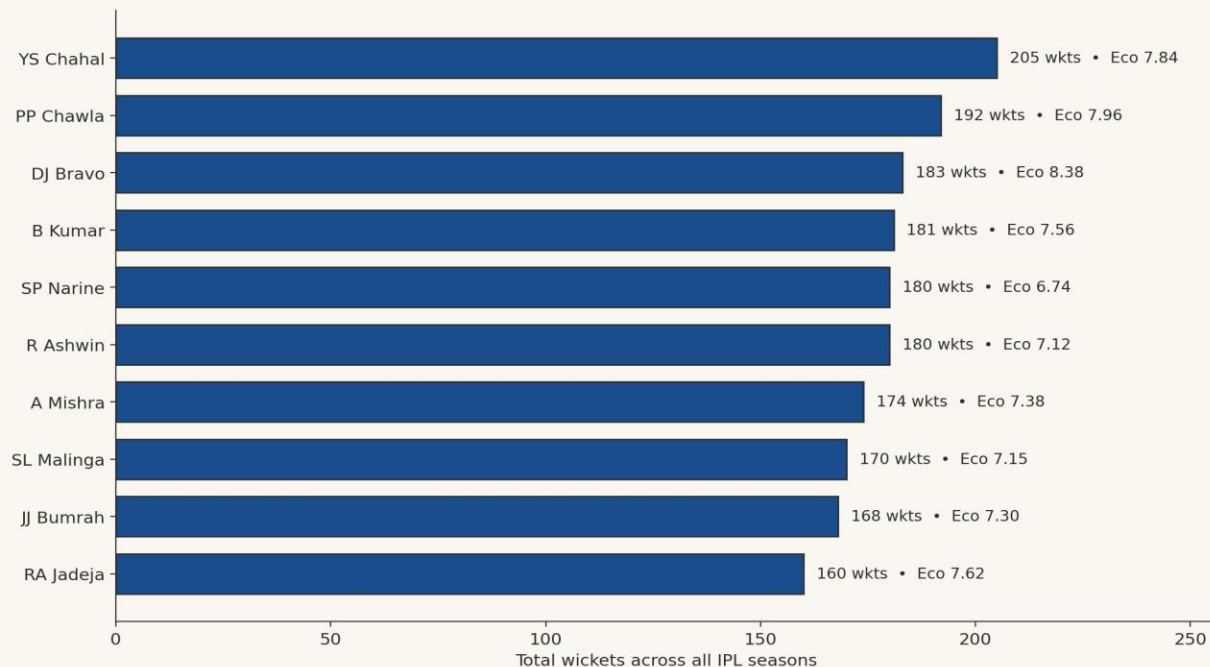
Virat Kohli leads with 8,014 runs across 244 innings — a 1,245-run cushion over second-place Dhawan.

AB de Villiers brings the highest SR (151.9) on this list; Gayle the highest boundary % (75.8).

Volume and impact rarely coexist — these two do.

Q3

The kings of wicket-taking

TOP 10 IPL WICKET-TAKERS (with economy rate)

**Chahal in front;
Narine the most
lethal.**

Yuzvendra Chahal leads with 205 wickets — first spinner to cross the 200 mark in the IPL era.

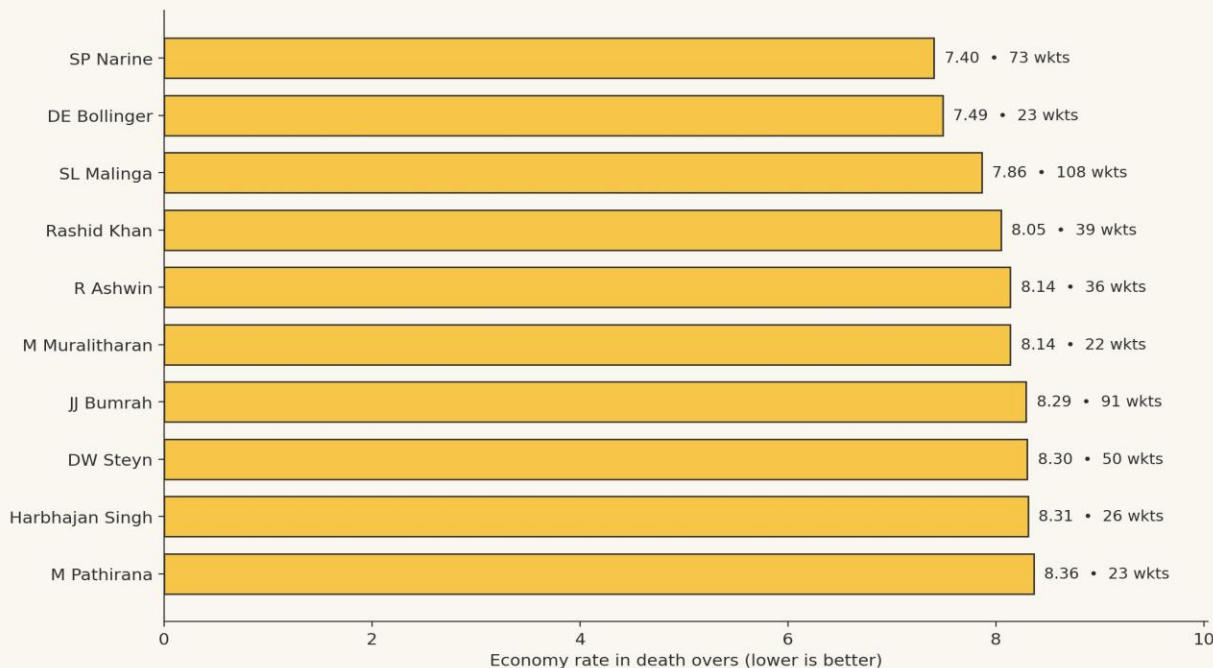
But the most efficient on this list: Sunil Narine, with an economy of just 6.74 across 180 wickets.

Wicket count is the headline. Economy is the truth.

Q3

Death-over specialists

THE DEATH-OVER SPECIALISTS (min 30 overs in overs 16-20)



The unsung guardians.

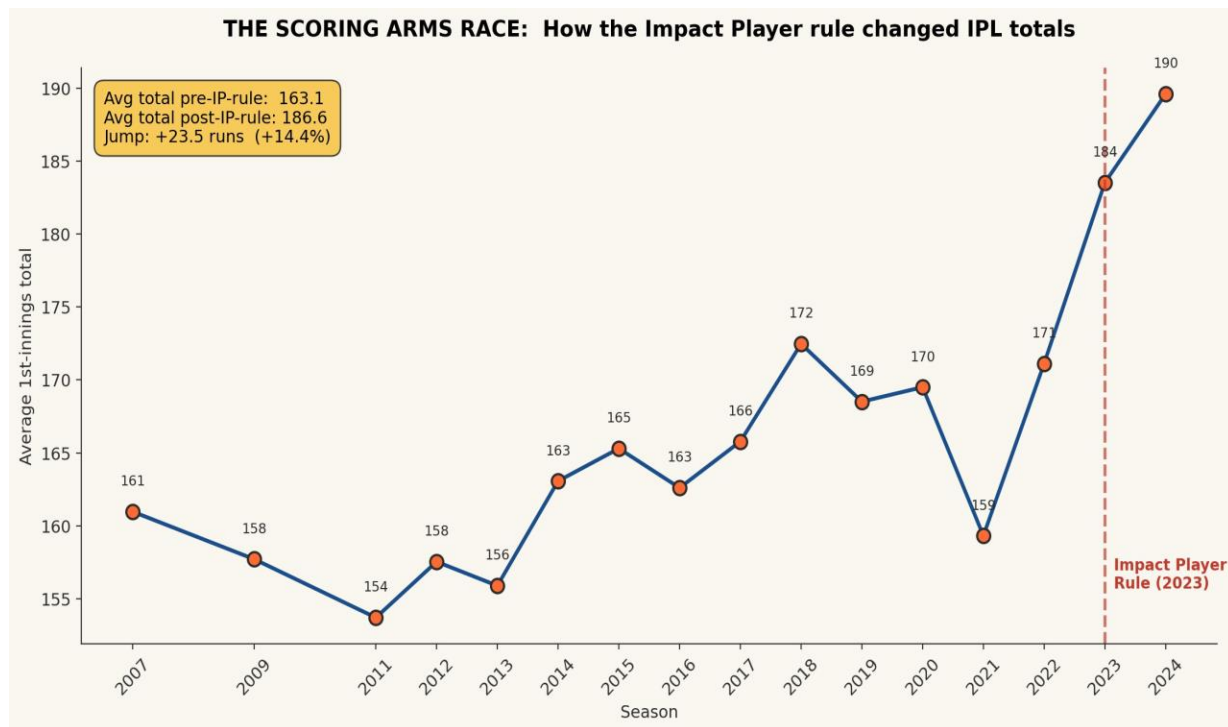
In the most punishing 5 overs of T20 cricket, Sunil Narine (7.40), Bollinger (7.49), and Malinga (7.86) bleed runs slower than anyone.

Bumrah ranks above Steyn and Harbhajan in pure economy — a stat his reputation usually understates.

These are the bowlers captains save their final over for.

Q4

The scoring arms race



+23.5 runs. Overnight.

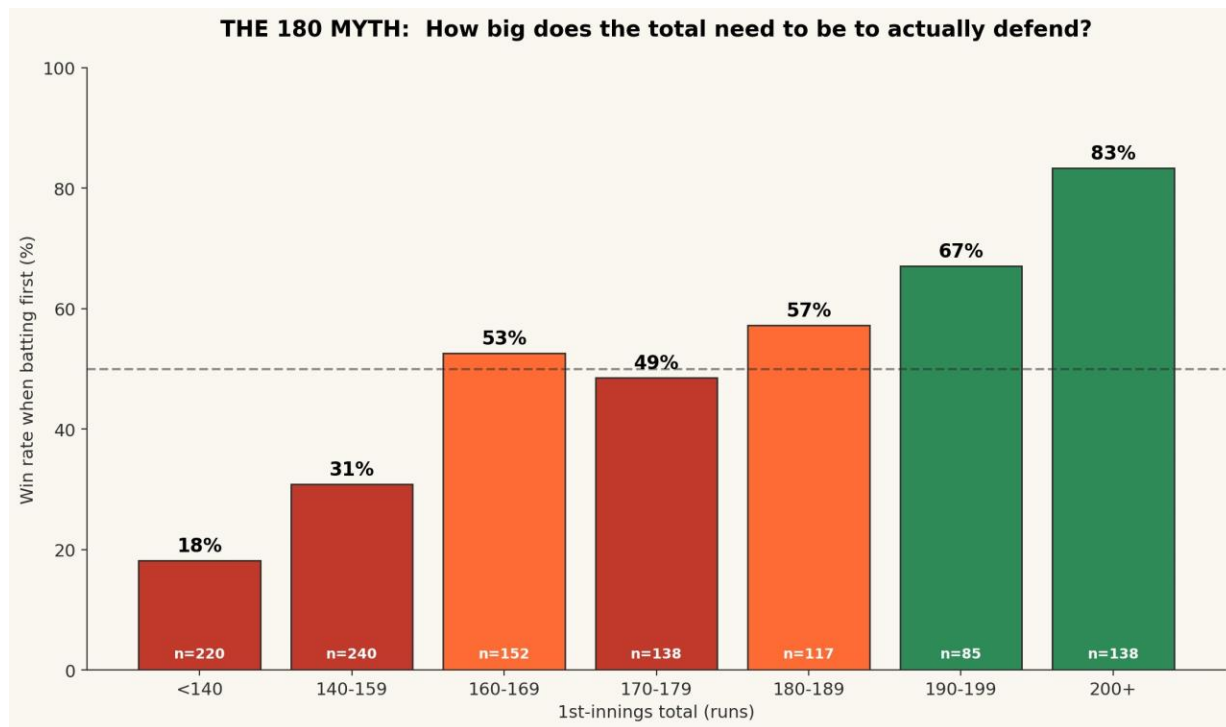
Average 1st-innings totals were stuck at ~163 for over a decade.

In IPL 2023, the Impact Player rule was introduced. Totals jumped to 184 — then 190 in 2024.

A 14.4% lift in one rule change. The biggest structural shift in IPL batting history.

Q4

The 180 myth



180 is not safe anymore.

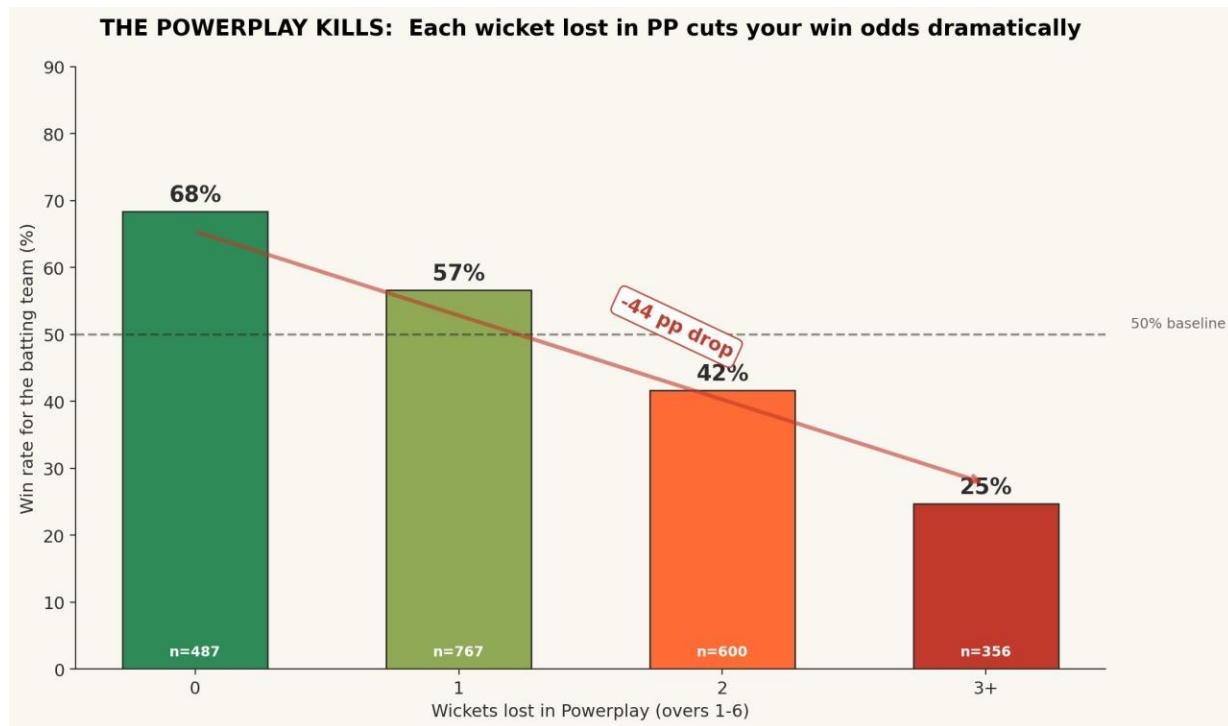
Teams that post 170-189 win only 49-57% of the time — basically a coin flip.

Cross 190, and the win rate jumps to 67%. Cross 200, and you win 83% of the time.

In the new IPL, the defendable threshold has shifted from 170 to 200.

Q5

The powerplay kills



-44 percentage points.

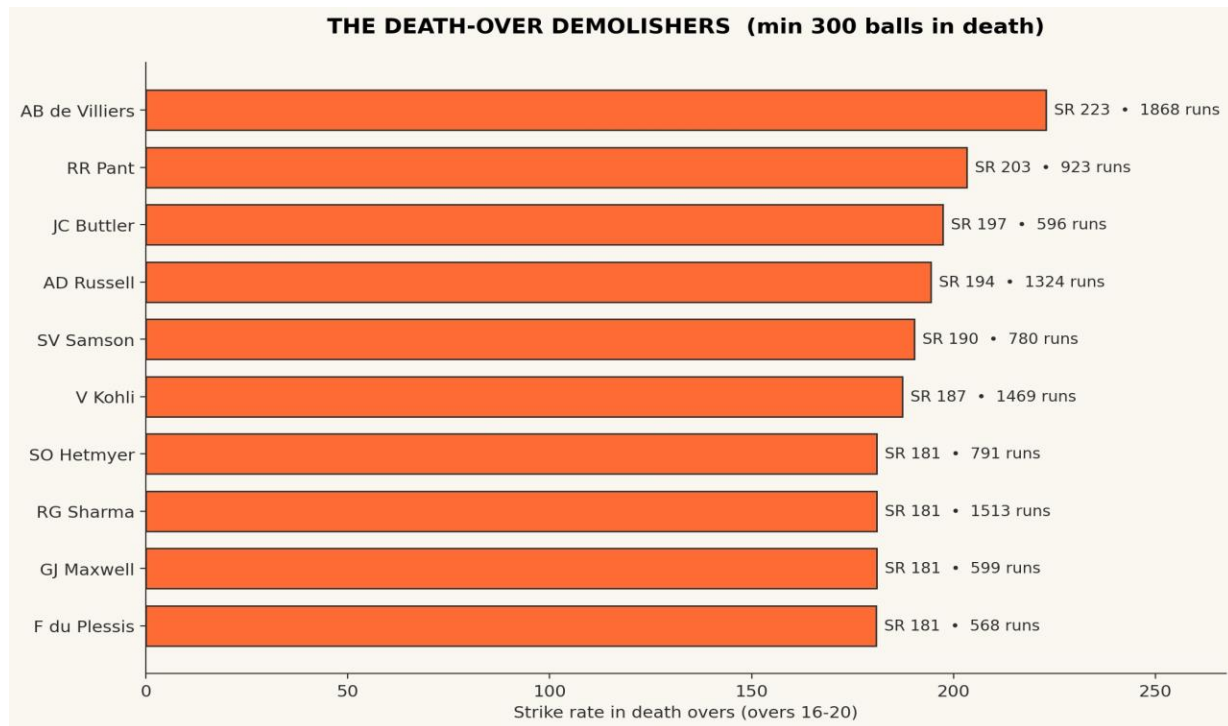
Walk out of the powerplay 0 down → you win 68% of the time.

Walk out 3+ down → you win just 25%.

That is a 44-point swing — fifteen times bigger than the toss. The most under-discussed predictor in the league.



Bonus — The death-over demolishers



AB still leads. Years later.

AB de Villiers strikes at 223 in death overs — a number no current player matches.

Rishabh Pant (203), Buttler (197), Russell (194) round out the modern elite.

Captains pay millions for these last 5 overs. Now you know who actually delivers them.

THE ONE INSIGHT THAT SURPRISED ME

1.6

percentage points

The boost from winning the toss

VS

44

percentage points

The damage from 3+ powerplay wickets

Cricket commentary obsesses over the toss. The data says: the powerplay is the real match.

Five questions, five data-backed answers

- | | | |
|----|-----------|---|
| Q1 | Toss | Toss winner edge: 1.6 pp. It is the decision (field-first +9 pp), not the toss itself, that matters. |
| Q2 | Phases | Death overs show the biggest winner-loser gap ($\Delta 1.87$ RPO). All three phases favour the winner. |
| Q3 | Players | Kohli leads scorers (8,014 runs). Chahal leads wicket-takers (205). Narine is the most efficient on both ends. |
| Q4 | IP Rule | Average 1st-innings total jumped 14.4% (163 $\rightarrow$ 187) post-2023. The defendable threshold has moved from 170 to 200. |
| Q5 | Powerplay | Each PP wicket lost cuts win probability by ~ 15 percentage points. 0 $\rightarrow$ 3+ = 68% $\rightarrow$ 25%. |

THANK YOU

Built with cricket, code, and curiosity.

FIND THE WORK

GitHub Repo: <https://github.com/CodeCraftsmanRohit/ipl-crunch-26>

Colab Notebooks: https://colab.research.google.com/drive/11JHJNFhoH_oGC3LUIHR0i6DJk1AQ9vgc?usp=sharing

Wooble Profile: <https://wooble.org/rohitkumarak51e15f3>